MARYLEBONE ROSTER · LINKS DESIGNER · THE SHORTLIST



Three good links, one edge each

Common Ground, Even Step and Short Run, against each other and against today's link

Prepared 6 Nov 2026 · every figure is computed from the rotas

What all three share

Each line holds for all three, better than or level with today; page 2 has what is worse, and why these three.

✓ All **9 of 9** December staffing rules (today 4), and all three flexible ones: 14 on a Saturday, evenly spaced cover weeks, weekday closers from 15:45

✓ **No avoidable fatigue warning**, cover weeks aside; one if a cover week falls badly — over 55 hours in seven days, with 8-hour cover duties. Never more than **five days in a row**, cover weeks aside; seven if a cover week falls badly (today 4 warnings, up to 5; 7 days in a row, up to 9)

✓ **About 14 full weekends off a year** (today 10), 7 in 26, never more than 5 weeks apart (today up to 7 apart)

✓ The same **35-hour** week and **218.6 days** a year, under the ceiling of 219 (today 219.0)

✓ Every closing shift **shorter, by 30 minutes to an hour** — the weekday's and Sunday's 8h 10m on all three (today 8h 40m and 8h 55m); no shift over 9h 00m

✓ **Every working week all earlies or all lates**, none mixing the two (today 7 of 16 mix them)

Where they differ

the better of the three on each line in bold green; today for scale, not ranked

MEASURE	TODAY	COMMON GROUND	EVEN STEP	SHORT RUN
Heaviest week, Mon–Sat	43h 50m	42h 30m	**42h 00m**	42h 30m
Lightest week, Mon–Sat	25h 10m	**25h 30m**	**25h 30m**	24h 30m
Shortest rest between shifts, fixed duties	12h 30m	**14h 35m**	**14h 35m**	14h 20m
Closing shift, Saturday	9h 10m	**8h 10m**	**8h 10m**	8h 40m
Earlies over 8h 30m, Mon–Sat, each a year	0	**0**	**0**	20
Any shift over 8h 30m, Mon–Sat, each a year	31	**0**	**0**	26
Earlies finishing before 14:00, each a year	26	**12**	10	0
Weekday lates, closers aside, on average	8h 30m	8h 30m	8h 27m	**8h 00m**
Weeks on one shift time Mon–Fri, all earlies or all lates	7 of 16	**19 of 21**	18 of 21	18 of 21
Week-to-week change of start	4h 00m	**1h 12m**	1h 30m	1h 14m
Shift times, and how many are new	18 (0 new)	**13 (6 new)**	**13 (5 new)**	15 (6 new)
New shift times on a Saturday	0	3	2	**1**
Single rest days, each a year	10	12	**8**	**8**
14 days' leave buys at best · leave for four weeks off	30 · 14	**30** · **14**	28 · 15	28 · 15
Fit to the trains, weekday · Sat · Sun (0 = exact)	52.0 · 65.9 · 70.2	32.7 · **9.8** · **28.6**	32.6 · 10.4 · 29.2	**29.1** · 13.6 · 29.2

Each one's edge

Common Ground CG-26-T8 · 03af96b2

Today's leave. 14 days buy 30 days off at best and four weeks off take 14, as today; no shift over 8h 30m on any day, alone of the three; one shift time Monday to Friday, all earlies or all lates, in 19 of 21 weeks, the gentlest change of start and the closest weekend fit (9.8 on a Saturday, 28.6 on a Sunday). Its cost: 12 single rest days a year, not 8, the weakest weekday fit (32.7) and four at the open.

Even Step ES-26-T5 · fb7a3988

Today's earlies, the steadiest weeks. Every early from Monday to Saturday one of today's times, no shift there over 8h 30m and today's 13:45 every weekday; the lightest heaviest week, 42h 00m, and the fewest new shift times, five. Its cost: the biggest change of start, 1h 30m, and 15 days' leave for four weeks off.

Short Run SR-26-F1 · 247f3636

The closest weekday fit, the shortest weekday lates. 29.1 against 32.6 and 32.7, and weekday lates of 8h 00m on average. Its cost: an 8h 40m Saturday closer, 14h 20m the shortest rest, no early finish before 14:00, 20 earlies a year over 8h 30m, all 9h 00m, and four weeks off for 15 days' leave.

Which one, by what matters most

IF THE MAIN PRIORITY IS	CHOOSE
Of these three, today's leave, or no shift over 8h 30m on any day	**Common Ground**
Of these three, every early one of today's times, and the steadiest weeks	**Even Step**
Of these three, the closest weekday fit and the shortest weekday lates	**Short Run**
OUTSIDE THE SHORTLIST	
A 16:00 closer Monday to Saturday, shorter than the three's	**Closing Time** · Both Ways too
The fewest new shift times: three	**Home Grown**
A fourth person to the Saturday close	**Even Keel** · Fine Tune too
The steadiest start times from week to week	**Second Edition**

THE SHORTLIST · CONTINUED

Against today, and how to choose

On most of what a colleague feels the three are the same, and a figure they share spans their columns

Against today's link a year: the rotation's count scaled to 52 weeks; days a year and full weekends off on page 1, the leave below

MEASURE	TODAY	COMMON GROUND	EVEN STEP	SHORT RUN
Saturdays a year, each	26		**28 on all three**	
Sunday overtime duties a year, each	21		**20 on all three**	
Starting at 06:20, each a year	62	48	60	60
Average shift, Mon–Sat	8h 14m		**8h 16m on all three**	

Why these three and not the other nineteen

Shortlisted on 5 Nov 2026: Common Ground, as the example of the links that keep today's leave; Even Step, then first in the pack's league; Short Run, which colleagues have seen. Since the Saturday ticket office lates moved to 22:30, Common Ground is first, just over half a point ahead of Even Step. Each other design has something, and pays for it:

In Step	steadier weekly hours — but the most long earlies, 40 a year each
Closing Time	shorter closers and a closer Saturday fit — but fewer weeks on one shift time and a weaker weekday fit
Both Ways	shorter closers and more early finishes — but fewer weeks on one shift time and more long shifts
Home Grown	the fewest new shift times, three — but today's 9h 10m Saturday closer and a weaker fit
Even Keel, Fine Tune	four at the Saturday close — but weeks mixing earlies and lates, and longer blocks
Second Edition	the steadiest start times from week to week — but six days in a row, cover weeks aside
Second Look	no 55-hour week at all — but six days in a row and fewer weeks on one shift time
Clean Slate	the best weekend fit of all — but ten new times, five on a Saturday
Next Step	a closer weekday fit and a gentler change of start than Even Step's — but 70 starts at 06:20 a year each, not 60, 20 finishes at 22:45 rather than 22:30, and one more new time
Fair Share	Next Step with an even Sunday, no long shifts — but a weaker Sunday fit, two more new times
Grand Tour	Common Ground's leave and a closer weekday fit — but fewer weeks on one shift time
Open Return, Short Openers	today's leave and no 55-hour week — but a 13h 15m shortest rest and more long shifts
Middle Ground	today's leave, with no two closing or 06:20 weeks side by side where Common Ground has both, for a larger change of start from week to week (1h 42m against 1h 12m). Which is better is a matter of preference: the hardest weeks apart, or steadier start times
Long Break	Common Ground's four weeks for 14 days' leave and fewer single rest days — but six days in a row
Balanced V5, Balanced V6	shorter runs of earlies or lates and more early finishes — but 22 single rest days a year, 7 of 21 weeks on one shift time
Balanced V7	the same gains — but 13 of 21 weeks on one shift time and three weeks mixing earlies and lates

The honest costs, against today

- **Late finishes.** 42 a year each at 23:00 or later on all three (today 39), and at 22:00 or later 94 on Common Ground and Even Step, 92 on Short Run (today 78). Three to the close every day, where today has two Monday to Saturday, means no link meeting the rules has fewer than 42 at 23:00 or later.
- **Longer blocks.** Up to 5 weeks of earlies or of lates in a row on all three, 7 with cover weeks beside them (today 2, up to 3).
- **Fewer long breaks.** Today five of its 17 rest-day breaks are three or four days, about 13 a year each; Common Ground has two, of three days, about 4 a year each, and the other two none.
- **Early finishes.** Fewer before 14:00 than today's 26 a year each: 12 on Common Ground, 10 on Even Step, none on Short Run.
- **Leave, on Even Step and Short Run.** 14 days' leave buys at best 28 days off, not today's 30, and four complete weeks off in a row, Sunday to Saturday, take 15 days' leave, not 14 — the two that people plan a year around. Common Ground keeps today's, for 12 single rest days a year, not 8. At worst 14 days buys 20 days off on all three, a day more than today's 19.
- **Saturdays.** About 2 more a year on all three (28, today 26): fourteen on a Saturday across 26 lines, today ten across 20.
- **New times.** 6 of Common Ground's 13 shift times are new, 5 of Even Step's 13, 6 of Short Run's 15: shorter versions of today's lates on each (three, three and four), and besides, a 07:00–15:30 early and two Sunday earlies on Common Ground; a 12:15–20:30 and a 9-hour Sunday early on Even Step; a longer weekday early and the Sunday early on Short Run.

How to choose each of the three is the one to choose for something different

- **Choose Common Ground** if keeping today's leave, or no shift over 8h 30m on any day, matters most — for 12 single rest days a year, a weaker weekday fit and four at the open.
- **Choose Even Step** if keeping today's earlies and steady weeks matters most — for a 1h 30m change of start and four weeks off for 15 days' leave.
- **Choose Short Run** if the weekday fit and short weekday lates matter most — for an 8h 40m Saturday closer, no 13:45, 20 earlies a year each over 8h 30m and four weeks off for 15 days' leave.